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Culture (OWC): [Tsonga \(FT06\)](#)

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Section Title(S)

TERMS OF KINSHIP AND CORRESPONDING PATTERNS OF BEHAVIOUR AMONG THE THONGA

CLASS VI.—BAHAHANA. (Paternal aunts.)

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Material Not Relevant

I would place here the paternal aunts in a special class. To this relationship corresponds a very important and characteristic pattern of behaviour. There are some divergences as regards the liberty of attitude allowed with the *hahane*. Some clans hold her in greater respect than others, and Natives belonging to these clans will say, "the *hahane* is a father, one cannot joke with her." But these cases are exceptional. For the majority of the Thonga people, a great familiarity with the *hahane* seems to be the rule. All kinds of jokes can be made in her presence, and a girl, even a boy, will not be ashamed to tell her all the foolish things they have done. She is the proper "confidente" of her nephews and nieces. If a boy or girl gets into trouble, especially in matters appertaining to sexual life, they will first of all tell their *hahane*, and ask her to break the news to their father. She will go and inform the mother of the child, who will tell her husband. Generally speaking, the *hahane* seems to be an intermediary between children and their father. If they do not get on well with their father, or if he obliges them to do something to which they object (for instance, in case of marriage) they can always seek refuge at the *hahane's* kraal. She will then go and plead their cause before the father. Very often when a child has thus put himself under the protection of his *hahane*, the father will give way. It is very noteworthy that the *hahane's* influence is greater than that of the paternal uncles.

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When a boy contemplates marriage, it is again the *hahane* to whom he applies for advice as regards the choice of a wife. She will tell him what reputation the girl has, upon whom he has set his affections, and whether there exists between the two families any kind of relationship prohibitive of marriage. If necessary, she will make discreet inquiries among the women as to the conduct and character of the girl and, in general, the suitability of the union.

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If a child is ill, and on the "bones" been consulted, the paternal ancestors are indicated as responsible for the disease, it is the *hahane* who will usually be shown by the oracles as the one who must offer the sacrifice of propitiation.

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